

Session 23: Judah and Joseph

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's curse on Shimon and Levi foreshadows the scattering of these two tribes.
- Yaaqov's blessing for Yehudah casts Yehudah as a new Yoseph.
- The story of David is patterned after the story of Yoseph.

Yaaqov's Blessing on His Twelve Sons

Genesis 49:1-2

Ya'akov Gathers His Sons

- **49:2** "Gather sons of Ya'akov, listen to Yisrael your father"

Genesis 49:3-12

Rival Sons of Leah

a - **49:3-4** Reuven

b - **49:5-7** Shim'on and Levi

a' - **49:8-12** **Yehudah (longest blessing)**

Genesis 49:13-21

49:13-17

Sons of Bilhah and Leah

- **49:13** Zevulun
- **49:14-15** Yissakhar
- **49:16-17** Dan

49:18

"For your deliverance I wait, O Yahweh!"

49:19-21

Sons of Bilhah and Zilpah

- **49:19** Gad
- **49:20** Asher
- **49:21** Naphtali

Genesis 49:22-27

Beloved Sons of Rakhel

- **49:22-26** Yoseph (longest blessing)
- **49:27** Binyamin

Genesis 49:28

Ya'akov Blesses His Sons

- “These are the tribes of Israel, and this is what their father said when he blessed them.”

Genesis 49:1-28. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Genesis 49 is a deathbed scene where the dying patriarch utters his final words to his sons.

¹ And **Yaaqov** called for **his sons** and said,

“Gather together and let me tell you all,
what will happen to you all at the end of days.

² Gather and **listen**, **sons of Yaaqov**,
and **listen** to **Yisrael your father** :

Genesis 49:1-2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The premise of this speech is that a person near death has clarity on matters that are usually opaque. As they draw near to the border of Heaven and Earth, they can see what is to come and anticipate the future. On his deathbed, Yaaqov gathers his sons and offers them a window into their future.

Notice the symmetrical design of the chapter.

- On the outer ends are the first four sons of Leah, with Yehudah receiving the largest and most significant blessing. // The conclusion comes with the two sons of Rachel, with Yoseph receiving the most robust blessing. This design places Yehudah and Yoseph in a parallel relationship, which is crucial to the overall strategy of the Genesis scroll.
- Inside of the two ends are matching lists of three sons.
- And in the very center of the chapter is an odd line that sticks out in the poem. It could be a statement in the mouth of Yaaqov, or it could be an interruption from the narrator to comment on the two

important blessings for Yehudah and Yoseph.

- Either way, this central statement frames the entire poem as a source of hope for future generations who see in these blessings a promise of future deliverance for their family.

Rival Sons of Leah

³ **Reuven**, you are my first-born,
my strength and the beginning of my vigor.

Excelling in dignity,
and **excelling** in **strength**

⁴ uncontrollable like water,
you will **not excel** !

a' Because **you went up** (עלית) on **the bed** of your father
b then you profaned **my couch** —
a' to **my couch** **he went up**!

⁵ **Shim'on and Levi**, brothers;
their schemes are weapons of violence.

⁶ Into their council may my life not enter,
to their assembly may my honor never be joined;
Because in **their anger** they murdered men,
and in **their pleasure** they hamstringed oxen.

⁷ Cursed be **their anger** for it is **strong**
and **their wrath**, because it is harsh.

I will divide them up among Ya'akov,
and I will scatter them among Yisra'el.

a ⁸ **Yehudah**, as for you, **your brothers will praise you** (יודוך).
b Your hand (ידך) will be on the neck of your enemies (איביך),
a' the **sons of your father** (אביך) **will bow down to you**.
a ⁹ A **cub of a lion** is Yehudah
b from the prey, my son, **you have gone up** (עלית) .
a' He crouches, he lies down, like a **lion**,
b' and like a **young lion**, **who will make him rise up** ?

¹⁰ **The scepter** will not depart from Yehudah
nor **the ruler's staff** from between his feet,
unto when he comes to whom it belongs,
and the obedience of the peoples will belong to him.

¹¹ Binding **his donkey to the vine**,
and **a son of his mare to the offshoot**,
he washes his clothing in **wine**,
and his robe **in the blood of grapes**.

¹² Eyes sparkle from **wine**,
and teeth white from **milk**!

Genesis 49:3-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Non-Blessing on Reuven

Genesis 49:3-4 Instructor's Translation

³ **Reuven**, you are my first-born,
my strength and the beginning of my vigor.
Excelling in dignity,
and **excelling** in **strength**
⁴ uncontrollable like water,
you will **not excel**!
Because **you went up** (עלית) on **the bed** of your father
then you profaned **my couch** —
to **my couch** **he went up!**

“My firstborn” activates the “reversal of the firstborn” pattern: the beasts (Gen. 1-2), Cain (Gen. 4), Japheth (Gen. 9-10), Ishmael (Gen. 21), Yaaqov (Gen. 25, 27), and Yehudah/Yoseph.

Notice how Yaaqov describes Reuven using the imagery and language of Genesis 1.

- The word “beginning” (ראשית) and “uncontrollable waters” recalls “tohu vavohu” (Gen. 1:2).

“You went up on the bed of your father” is a reference to the story in Genesis 35:22: “It came about while Israel was dwelling in that land, that Reuven went and lay with Bilhah, his father’s concubine, and Israel heard.” This was Reuven’s grab for power by sleeping with the slave of Yaaqov’s favorite wife Rachel after she died.

While Yaaqov does not curse Reuven, he certainly does not pass on the firstborn blessing to him.

The Chronicler reflected back on this story and retold it in this way.

1 Chronicles 5:1-2 NASB*

¹ Now the sons of **Reuven the firstborn** of Israel
(for he was the firstborn,

but because he defiled his father's bed,
his birthright was given to the sons of Yoseph the son of Israel;
so that he is not enrolled in the genealogy according to the birthright.

² Though **Yehudah prevailed over his brothers**,
and from him came the leader,
yet **the firstborn right belonged to Yoseph**)

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"While Reuben is the biological oldest son, his corresponding rights of status were transferred to Joseph. Yet, even Joseph realized this birthright only to a certain extent, since 'Judah became strong among his brothers.' The author here suggests, then, three levels of priority among the sons of Jacob: the biological firstborn, the legally nominated elder, and the one who wielded actual authority. ... In full accord with his general world-view, the Chronicler explains Reuben's loss of his birthright as a punishment for sin, a theological conviction which is presented as an interpretation of texts in Genesis. ... The transfer of the birthright to Joseph is the second stage of the midrashic course. The legal implication of Jacob's words in Genesis 48:5, 'And now, your two sons ... Ephraim and Manasseh shall be mine, as Reuben and Simeon are,' is that these sons of Joseph are raised to the status of full membership among the tribes of Israel. In terms of inheritance, Joseph's portion in Jacob's inheritance was increased from one part (which would have been divided among his descendants) to two."

Japhet, Sara (2013). [I & II Chronicles: A Commentary](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 133.

The Curse on Shimon and Levi

Genesis 49:5-7 Instructor's Translation

⁵ **Shimon and Levi**, brothers;
their schemes are weapons of violence.
⁶ **Into their council** may my life not enter,
to their assembly may my honor never be joined;
because in **their anger** they murdered men,
and in their pleasure they hamstrung oxen.
⁷ Cursed be **their anger** for it is **strong**
and **their wrath**, because it is harsh.
I will divide them up among Yaaqov,
and I will scatter them among Israel.

The poem reflects back on the narrative of [Genesis 34](#), where Shimon and Levi led the massacre of the Canaanites in Shkhem. Even the vocabulary is linked to the narrative.

- "in their anger" (באפם) → "and they were very angry" (ויהר להם מאד, [Gen. 34:7](#))
- "they killed a man" (הרגו איש) → "and they killed every male" (ויהרגו כל זכר, [Gen. 34:25](#))

The curse (ארור) brought on Levi and Shimon sets them on analogy with Cain ([Gen. 4:11](#)) and with Ham ([Gen. 9:25](#)), who acted shamefully or murderously against their own family members and were exiled and cursed.

It is important to note, however, that the curse on Levi is reversed at Mount Sinai in the golden calf debacle, where Levi's violence earns him a "blessing" (Exod. 32:29) as he executes the idolators who worshipped the golden calf.

The "angry murder" pattern is activated here, linking Shimon and Levi to Cain, Lamech, Esau, and the brothers of Yoseph.

Yaaqov says that Shimon and Levi will be "scattered" (פּוּץ) and "divided" (חֵלֶק). These are the same words associated with the division of the nations during the Babylon debacle (see Gen. 11:8-9 and Deut. 32:8-9). This is reflected in the biblical version of Israel's history, where Levi is selected out of the tribes and not counted among them. As for Shimon, after the tribes go into the land under the leadership of Joshua, the tribe of Shimon is never heard of again (their appearance in Judges 1:3, 17 is their last in the Torah-Former Prophets).

Reflection Question

What are some of the ways the story of David follows the pattern of the Yoseph story?